

# Sitemap Generation Improvement — Design Spec

**Date:** 2026-03-21 **Scope:** Replace RTD's minimal 4-URL auto-sitemap with full per-page sitemap via sphinx-sitemap **Delivery:** 1 PR

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## Problem

The current sitemap at <https://docs.vyos.io/sitemap.xml> is auto-generated by Read the Docs and contains only 4 URLs (one per active version root). None of the ~250 individual documentation pages are listed, severely limiting search engine discoverability.

## Solution

Add the sphinx-sitemap extension to the Sphinx build. Each version build produces a sitemap.xml with every page. RTD merges these into a sitemapindex.xml at the domain root, replacing the current stub.

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## Changes

### 1. Add dependency

**File:** requirements.txt

Add sphinx-sitemap==2.6.0 to the existing dependencies list (pinned for consistency with other dependencies; compatible with Sphinx 7.2.6).

### 2. Configure Sphinx

**File:** docs/conf.py

Add to extensions list:

```
'sphinx_sitemap',
```

Add configuration variables:

```
html_baseurl = 'https://docs.vyos.io/'
sitemap_url_scheme = '{lang}{version}{link}'
sitemap_locales = [None]
```

### Configuration rationale:

- `html_baseurl` — Required by sphinx-sitemap for absolute URLs. RTD overrides this per-version automatically during builds. Note: local builds will use this URL (pages won't resolve locally, but this is expected).
- `sitemap_url_scheme` = `'{lang}{version}{link}'` — Set explicitly for clarity, though this is the default when used with RTD. Matches RTD's URL structure (`/en/latest/page.html`, `/en/1.4/page.html`). The `{lang}` placeholder is future-proofed for i18n.
- `sitemap_locales` = `[None]` — Suppresses language variants until translations are configured. English-only for now.

**Page exclusions:** sphinx-sitemap does not support a `sitemap_excludes` list. Utility pages like `search.html` and `genindex.html` will appear in the sitemap, which is acceptable — search engines handle these gracefully and including them has no negative SEO impact.

### 3. No changes needed

- **`docs/_html_extra/robots.txt`** — Already points to `https://docs.vyos.io/sitemap.xml`. No change required.
  - **`.readthedocs.yml`** — No sitemap-specific config needed. RTD automatically detects and merges per-build sitemaps.
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## RTD Integration

When sphinx-sitemap is present in a Sphinx build on RTD:

1. Each version build produces `sitemap.xml` in its build output (e.g., `/en/latest/sitemap.xml`)
2. RTD detects the per-version sitemaps and generates a `sitemapindex.xml` at the domain root
3. The domain-root `sitemap.xml` becomes a sitemap index referencing each version's sitemap
4. The `robots.txt` Sitemap: directive already points to the right URL

**Expected result:** `https://docs.vyos.io/sitemap.xml` will contain references to: - `https://docs.vyos.io/en/latest/sitemap.xml` (~250 URLs) - `https://docs.vyos.io/en/1.4/sitemap.xml` (~250 URLs) - `https://docs.vyos.io/en/1.3/sitemap.xml` (~250 URLs) - `https://docs.vyos.io/en/1.2/sitemap.xml` (~250 URLs)

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## Future: i18n Readiness

When translations are introduced:

1. Change `sitemap_locales = [None]` to `sitemap_locales = ['en', 'de', ...]` (or whatever languages are added)
  2. sphinx-sitemap automatically generates hreflang alternate links in each sitemap entry
  3. No other configuration changes needed
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## Verification

After merging and RTD rebuilds all versions:

1. Fetch `https://docs.vyos.io/sitemap.xml` — should be a `sitemapindex` referencing per-version sitemaps
2. Fetch `https://docs.vyos.io/en/latest/sitemap.xml` — should contain ~250 `<url>` entries with absolute URLs
3. Verify individual page URLs are present (e.g., `configuration/firewall/index.html`)
4. Submit updated sitemap to Google Search Console (if configured)